Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Charlotte Anna Perkins Gilman's "To the Indifferent Women"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the effective use of repetition in Charlotte Anna Perkins Gilman's "To the Indifferent Women" include

alliteration,
ambiguity,
anaphora,
apostrophe,
assonance,
asyndeton,
blank verse,
didacticism,
envoy (*envoi*),
feminist critique,
imagery,
polyptoton,
polysyndeton,
repetition,
rhetorical question,
sestina,
sigmatism,
speaker,
stanza,
tone,
tristich, and
utopian.

The young writer should note that the poem is a sestina, a closed form characterized by repetition. A strong analysis will point to the last stanza, what might be considered didactic envoy, as the poem's summary and conclusion wherein the threads of repetition are brought together for full effect.

The poem's schemes of repetition, including alliteration, anaphora, assonance, asyndeton, polyptoton, polysyndeton, and, to a purpose in this poem, the rhetorical question, are contributory to the poem's message, and should be sampled as contributory. There is no need to rehearse every device of repetition.